Enric Vila-Villasante

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Research Fields

Primary: Education Economics, Development Economics, Applied Microeconomics
Secondary: Behavioral Economics, Policy Evaluation

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, Utrecht University 2023 – 2027
Defense expected Apr. 2027; dissertation submitted Aug. 2026

Visiting Ph.D. Student, University of Bologna Spring 2026

M.Sc. in Economic Policy, Utrecht University 2018 – 2019

B.Sc. in Economics, Universitat Pompeu Fabra 2013 – 2017

Research

My PhD research in Bulgaria involved primary data collection among 1,000 households, including the implementation of a lab-in-the-field experiment, survey design and piloting, and coordination with local partners and data collection agencies. For the projects in Kenya, I led the data cleaning, analysis, and writing of results of two randomized controlled trials of educational interventions in Kenyan schools.

Job Market Paper

Social Preferences as Human Capital: Intergenerational Transmission in an Ethnically Diverse Context

Manuscript available

Prosociality is essential for cooperation and the functioning of human societies, and is associated with important economic outcomes such as income, labor market prospects, or welfare. Social preferences are a key determinant of prosocial behavior. Yet, despite their central role in shaping behavior, relatively little is known about how these preferences are formed and what factors shape them. In this paper, I study how ethnic identity and parental influence are associated with social preferences. To do so, I elicit social preferences across 842 parent-child pairs from both ethnic majority and Roma minority in Bulgaria using survey- and task-based items. The results indicate that prosocial behavior and a preference for the in-group are common in this context and are positively associated between generations. I also find that in-group preferences are driven by a relatively small number of individuals across groups, as a majority of parents and children do not display an in-group or out-group preference. I also explore potential mechanisms associated with the intergenerational correlation of social preferences. In ethnic majority households, positive stereotypes, daily contact with the out-group, and a prosocial parenting style are associated with the intergenerational correlation of social preferences. Conversely, in ethnic Roma households, only a prosocial parenting style is associated with this intergenerational correlation.

Working Papers

Not Too Easy, Not Too Hard: The Effect of Levelled Problem Sets on Mathematics Outcomes (with Guthrie Gray-Lobe, Joseph Kassim, Joost de Laat, and Michael Kremer)

Manuscript available

The paper presents the results of two randomized controlled trials assessing personalized mathematics practice in Kenyan primary schools. The intervention tailored practice exercises to students' competence levels while keeping classroom instruction fixed. The first study involved 3,297 grade 4 students and the second involved

1,601 grade 6 students. We do not find an effect of personalized practice on mathematics test scores, either on average or across students' baseline achievement levels.

Promoting Early Childhood Education at Home: Experimental Evidence from Kenya (with Guthrie Gray-Lobe, Joost de Laat, and Michael Kremer)

Manuscript available

The paper presents the results of a randomized controlled trial assessing a remote parenting intervention. The parents of 1,450 pre-primary students in Kenyan schools received numeracy and literacy exercises to implement at home with their children twice per week. We do not find an effect of the at-home learning activities on students' test scores.

Work in Progress

Differences in Children's Self-views between Ethnic Groups (with Eddie Brummelman, Yingshi Huang, Thomas van Huizen, and Joost de Laat) *[Analysis ongoing]*

Teacher Absences and Student Achievement: Evidence from COVID-19 Quarantines in Catalonia *[Preliminary analysis completed; additional administrative data required.]*

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, Data Analysis (B.Sc.) — Fall 2026
Tasks: Led practical sessions; guided students through weekly cases — *Universitat Pompeu Fabra*

Instructor, Statistics (B.Sc.) — Spring 2023
Tasks: Delivered lectures; adapted lecture materials; graded examinations — *Utrecht University*

Teaching Assistant, Applied Data Analysis and Visualization II (B.Sc.) — Spring 2023
Tasks: Led practical sessions; guided students through weekly problem sets — *Utrecht University*

TA / Guest Lecturer, Economics of Global Challenges (M.Sc.) — Spring 2022, 2025, 2026
Tasks: Prepared course materials (2022); delivered guest lectures on coding practices — *Utrecht University*

Fellowships and Grants

Collegio dei Fiamminghi fellowship, Utrecht University — 2026

PhD Internal Funding grant, Utrecht University — 2023

Presentations

University of Bologna (internal seminar) — 2026
International Workshop on Applied Economics of Education (IWAEE) [poster] — 2026
Society of Economics of the Household Conference — 2026
Doctorissimes 2026 — 2026
AlpPop 2026 [poster] — 2026
Spanish Economic Association Annual Symposium — 2025
REACH Conference [poster] — 2025
3rd Dutch Development Economics PhD Workshop [poster] — 2025
Workshop on Socio-Emotional Skills and Education – University of Trento — 2025
Leuven Economics of Education Research (LEER) — 2025

Work Experience

Junior Researcher December 2019 - August 2023
Centre for Global Challenges - Utrecht University

Research Assistant to Dr. Anton-Giulio Manganelli April 2018 - August 2018
Centre de Recerca en Economia i Salut (CRES) - Universitat Pompeu Fabra

Skills and Languages

Skills: Stata, R, LaTeX

Languages: Catalan (native), Spanish (native), English (fluent), Italian (beginner)